

SALES MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Sales Manager Essentials — Day 1: Sales Strategy, Priorities, and Business Alignment

Study guide · Self-study

Day 1: Sales Strategy, Priorities, and Business Alignment

How to Use This Guide

You already sell well. This guide is about the step up: owning the direction of selling for a whole team, branch or territory rather than running your own pipeline. Day 1 of this course is about strategy and priorities — deciding where the selling effort should go, and being honest about what will not get it.

Work through the sections in order. Read the explanations, study the examples, then do the reflections in writing. Write your answers before you read the model answers at the end. The model answers are examples, not scripts; your words should sound like you, in your market.

The guide asks you to use your real pipeline and accounts, but not real numbers you do not have yet. Where a calculation is needed, you will work through a clearly labeled practice example with fictional numbers until you have your own records.

> **NOTES**
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> You do not need a team reporting to you to use this guide. If you are aspiring, use the accounts, segments and selling effort of the team you work in, or the one you would like to lead.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

This course uses KASU, MEDJAY's framework for structuring objectives, developed by Steven Saad. It has 4 steps: Knowledge, Attitude, Skill and Upskill. Here are yours for today.

Knowledge: You will know what makes a sales priority a real priority, and how to link each one to a business objective, a segment or channel, and the resources it will need.

Attitude: You will accept that choosing priorities means choosing what not to pursue, and that a short list you can defend beats a long list that spreads effort evenly.

Skill: You will be able to write a one-page sales priority plan that links each priority to a business objective, names the segment or channel it serves, and states what will deliberately not be pursued this cycle.

Upskill: You will be able to present that plan to the people who will deliver it and defend the trade-offs with evidence and capacity, not opinion.

From Salesperson to Owner of Sales Direction

A strong salesperson asks, "What do I need to close this week?" A sales manager asks, "Where should our selling effort go this cycle, and what will it cost us to put it there?" The first question is about effort. The second is about direction.

If you keep running the unit's selling day to day, two problems appear. First, your best people learn that all accounts and all requests get equal attention — so small, comfortable work fills the calendar. Second, nobody is reading the market. Neither problem is about laziness. It is human: when you have built a career on responding to clients, stopping to choose feels like neglecting them.

The sales manager's direction has to come from the business's objectives, not from the loudest account. The business has goals — enter a segment, protect a core account base, grow a channel, improve margin. Your job is to translate those goals into a small set of sales priorities, check the market and resources can support them, and say plainly what you will not do this cycle.

The psychology matters here too. People follow direction they can see the logic in. A rep who understands why a segment is a priority will make better calls without asking you. A rep handed a list of ten priorities will choose the easy ones.

Reading Your Target Markets and Channels

Before you set a priority you need a clear picture of the market it serves: who the buyer is, what they are buying, how they buy, and how you currently reach them.

Ask three plain questions about each segment you could pursue:

What does this buyer actually need, and why now? Look for the job they are trying to get done, not just a product category they might buy. A buyer who needs a reliable supply for a seasonal rush is a different opportunity from one planning a long-term switch.

How does this segment buy? Direct, through distributors, through partners, online, by tender, through a single decision-maker or a small committee. The channel shapes the sales effort you need and the speed you can expect.

How strong is our reach today? Do we already have relationships, references and a track record, or would we be starting cold?

Most managers find two or three segments that look attractive and only one they can serve well right now. That gap between attractive and servable is where priorities are decided.

Sizing Opportunities Without Overclaiming

You cannot prioritize on enthusiasm. You need a rough size for each opportunity, and you need to label how rough it is.

Use a simple structure. For each segment or channel, estimate the number of potential buyers, the buying frequency or cycle, and the share you could realistically win. Every one of those is an assumption until you have evidence. Write each assumption down, with a note on what evidence you have (your own pipeline history, a small set of won and lost deals, a test that has been run) and what is still a guess.

Practice example: A distributor estimates 400 potential contractor buyers in its region. Assume its records show it currently serves 60 of them and that reps typically convert roughly one in four prospects who agree to a full account review. Assume a team of six reps can run 8 full account reviews a month across the whole group. That is about a third of a new account per rep per month — enough to make the segment worth a priority only if the business objective is growth in that segment and the team can be freed from low-value calls to do it.

The lesson is not the numbers, which are fictional. The lesson is the discipline: size first, name your assumptions, then decide if the size matters to the business objective. A segment that is large but slow to convert is a different priority from one that is small but fast.

> **NOTES**
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> The common mistake here is sizing with hope: picking the biggest market share figure and treating it as a forecast. Label every figure that is an assumption.

Building the Priority Plan

A sales priority plan is one page. It has to be short enough to remember and specific enough to guide a week of decisions. Each priority on it needs four things.

First, the business objective it serves, in the business's own language. "Grow share in the after-market channel" is an objective. "Sell more" is not.

Second, the segment or channel it serves. Name the buyers and how you reach them.

Third, the sales effort and resources it will take: rep time, specialist support, marketing, samples, visits, partner capacity. A priority with no resources is a wish.

Fourth, and hardest, the explicit list of what will deliberately not be pursued this cycle. This is the part most plans leave out. It is also the part that makes the plan real. "We are not pursuing the smallest accounts through field visits this cycle; they will be served through inside support and the partner channel."

Keep the list to a small number of priorities. If everything is a priority, nothing is, and the team will default to what is easiest. You will get better at balancing growth ambitions against constraints by writing the constraint next to each ambition: "We want to grow the new segment, and we can only afford two reps on it while the core accounts are protected."

Balancing Growth Ambition Against Constraints

Growth ambitions run into three constraints again and again: team capacity, cash and time to result. Your plan has to live inside all three.

Team capacity is the one managers most often forget. The same reps you want on a new segment are the ones servicing existing accounts. Every hour on the new priority is an hour off something else. Write the trade-off down. If the plan needs two reps trained and one specialist brought in, say so, and say what shifts off their plates to make it happen.

Time to result is the second. Some priorities pay back in a few weeks; some take a full cycle. Both can be right, but the business needs to know which is which. A plan that promises fast growth from a slow-moving channel is a plan that will be rewritten under pressure.

The third is the honesty constraint. When you present the plan, you present the constraint. You never want a plan that tells the business only what it wants to hear. You want a plan that says: "Here

is what we can do within our resources, here is what that buys, and here is what we would need to do more."

> **NOTES**
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> When you feel resistance to writing a constraint down, ask yourself what would happen if the team missed the objective and you had never named the constraint.

Apply It in Your Role

Outside Sales: map your territory by segment and channel. Write down the two or three segments where your buyer's need, your reach and the business objective line up. Then write the smallest accounts you will deliberately stop visiting this cycle and how they will be served instead.

Inside Sales: your constraint is often time on the phone and support tickets. Choose which segments get proactive outreach and which get reactive support only. Name the buyers you will stop calling first.

Counter Sales: your buyer's need is speed and availability, and your channel is the counter itself. Decide which account types get priority service and which get self-serve or online support, and write the routing rule so it is consistent every day.

Sales Management: take the plan you wrote today and check it against the resources the business has already committed. If a priority has no resources, either take it off or escalate the gap in the plan itself.

No sales manager role yet? Do the same task with a business you know well (a past employer or a chain you buy from), or with the practice examples in this guide.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each before reading the model answers at the end.

1. Your business leader says, "I want us to grow in the new segment this quarter." Your team is already at full capacity on core accounts. What do you say?

2. A senior rep pushes back: "We've always visited every account. Cutting small accounts will lose us business." How do you respond?

3. Someone asks what your priorities are this cycle. Give the one-page answer, out loud, in under a minute.

Key Takeaways

- Your job is direction, not the selling day; a priority is a choice to spend effort in one place and accept spending less somewhere else.
- Every priority needs a business objective, a segment or channel, a resource, and a named thing you will not pursue.

- Size opportunities with labeled assumptions, not hope; separate the attractive from the servable.
- Growth ambitions live inside constraints: team capacity, time to result, and honest reporting to the business.
- A plan your team can see the logic in gets executed without you in the room.

Quiz

Read the five questions and choose one option each. Write your answers down before you check the key.

1. Which of these is a real sales priority rather than a wish?

   A. "Sell more across all segments this quarter."

   B. "Grow share in the service channel by freeing two reps from small-account visits."

   C. "Try to be more strategic."

   D. "Focus on whatever comes in this week."

2. You are sizing a new segment. Which approach is right?

   A. Use the biggest market figure you find and treat it as a forecast.

   B. Estimate buyers, frequency and win share, and label each figure as an assumption until evidence exists.

   C. Skip sizing; the new segment is clearly exciting.

   D. Only size the segment after the team has been selling there for a year.

3. What most often gets left out of a priority plan, yet makes it real?

   A. The list of what will deliberately not be pursued this cycle.

   B. A currency figure for every account.

   C. A promise of fast results in every segment.

   D. A longer list of priorities.

4. A senior rep says, "We've always visited every account." What is the strongest response?

   A. Agree to keep visiting every account to keep the peace.

   B. Acknowledge the rep's loyalty to the account base, then ask a calibrated question about which accounts the freed time would best serve.

   C. Tell the rep they are wrong and move on.

   D. Handle it by quietly cutting the visits yourself without telling anyone.

5. A business leader demands immediate growth in a channel you know takes a full cycle to build. What do you do?

   A. Promise the growth anyway to keep the leader happy.

   B. Say it is impossible and refuse to try.

   C. Present the plan with the time-to-result constraint named, what can be done inside it, and what you would need to do more.

D. Quietly change the numbers in the forecast.

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 2, write your real one-page sales priority plan and present it to at least one colleague or your manager.

- ☐ Choose two or three segments or channels worth pursuing for the business's objectives.
- ☐ For each, write the business objective it serves, in the business's language.
- ☐ For each, name the segment or channel and the sales effort and resources it takes.
- ☐ Write each assumption you made to size it, labeled as an assumption.
- ☐ Write the list of what you will deliberately not pursue this cycle.
- ☐ Name one constraint you have and how the plan lives inside it.
- ☐ Present it out loud in under two minutes and answer one question about the trade-offs.
- ☐ No team yet? Write the plan for a business you know well and present it to a friend who will challenge one trade-off.

Practice example: Your written plan says: Priority A — grow share in the maintenance channel; business objective — protect recurring revenue; segment — facilities buyers via direct reps; resource — two reps, one specialist; assumption — one in four reviews converts to a trial; not pursuing — field visits to accounts below a small annual spend, served by inside support.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your wording should sound like you.

1. "I can see the growth you want in the new segment, and it matters. The team is fully loaded on core accounts right now, so the question is what we move to make room. Would you like me to bring a plan that frees two reps for the new segment and names what shifts off, so we protect the core while we grow?" This works because it acknowledges the ambition without agreeing to an impossible load, and it asks an open question that moves to a plan instead of a debate.

2. "You have been loyal to these accounts for years, and that is exactly why I want your read on this. If we freed the visits to our smallest accounts and served them through inside support, what would you want to check to be sure we don't lose anything important?" Acknowledge first, do not defend the decision at the rep, then ask a genuine how or what question. You get the rep's knowledge in the room instead of resistance outside it.

3. "Two priorities this cycle. First, grow share in the maintenance channel, because it protects recurring revenue; two reps and one specialist work it. Second, strengthen the partner channel to reach buyers we do not visit directly. What we are not pursuing this cycle: field visits to our smallest accounts, which move to inside support. The constraint is rep time; that is what the two-rep allocation reflects." Under a minute, with the not-pursued list in it.

Quiz answers:

1. B. A priority links an objective, a segment and a resource, and names what shifts off — the other options commit to everything at once.

2. B. Sizing is an evidence exercise; figures are assumptions until your own records support them.

3. A. The "not pursued" list is the part most plans leave out, and it is what makes the plan guide real decisions.

4. B. Acknowledge first and ask a genuine how or what question — a full A.R.T.-style chain applied to an internal conversation, not a fight.

5. C. You report constraints and risks honestly and name what the resources buy.

References

Center for Creative Leadership (CCL)